

Chapter 159 - Extra One

The blazing summer had passed, yet autumn had not arrived. The late summer wind blew from the sea, sweeping over the thunderous waters of the Eastern Desolation¹, passing through the bustling traffic of Dongyang City², squeezing through the peaceful and leisurely Dianxing Town³, and by the time it reached the peak of Cloud Ascension Mountain⁴, it had gained a touch of coolness.

The red clouds had already faded. Disciples who had just finished their morning meal walked in small groups past the front of the Tranquil Mountain Palace⁵, yawning as they headed toward the Hanging Beam Garden⁶. A few disciples who had entered the sect just days ago were full of energy, laughing and chattering, finding everything fascinating.

"Shh, keep your voices down. Do you dare make loud noises in front of the sect leader's residence? Are you waiting to be expelled from the sect?" A young girl stepped forward to pull over a little girl who wasn't very old, covering her mouth with her hand.

The little girl stumbled as she was pulled, her eyes opening wide as she looked toward the Tranquil Mountain Palace beside them, hurriedly closing her mouth in panic.

"In front of the sect leader? So this is where the Chu Ling Divine Venerable⁷ lives?" The little girl was both afraid and excited, tugging at the young girl's sleeve. "Sister Wanwan, during today's lessons, will we be able to see the Divine Venerable?"

Qiu Wanwan⁸ laughed and pushed the girl's nose, scolding lovingly: "Dream on! Lessons are always taught by the elders, never by the sect leader. Besides, the Divine Venerable just returned from her wanderings a few days ago. If you want to see her, you'll probably have to wait until the initiation ceremony in a few days."

The girl said "alright" with disappointment clear in her voice.

The groups of disciples dispersed, leaving only silence in front of the Tranquil Mountain Palace, with occasional earth-shaking yawns echoing back and forth.

The person dozing lightly in the small building above was awakened by such yawns and lazily opened her eyes.

The sandalwood fragrance suppressed other scents in the room. The wind lifted the curtains that blocked the sunlight at the window, and the bright light fell on her eyelids, making her eyes ache.

"Yiyi⁹." Chu Qingqiu was too lazy to even move her fingers, only speaking aloud, her ending tone drawn out in long laziness, like unconscious coquetry.

Ning Fuyi, who had been up early playing with a red wooden box beside her, only then looked up, strode over to pull the curtains closed, then returned to the table to continue her tinkering.

Chu Qingqiu's gaze followed her approach and return. Ning Fuyi, absorbed in the box, didn't notice the increasingly dissatisfied coolness in her eyes.

The red wooden box in her hands was called "Three Sleepless Nights"¹⁰," meaning it couldn't be opened for three days and nights. It was a recent invention by Hua Feihua¹¹ to amuse herself during boring times, and had recently become very popular among the major sects, with almost everyone having one.

It was said that so far, no one had been able to solve it within three days. Ning Fuyi initially had no interest, but Hua Feihua insisted on making a bet with her, boasting that if Ning Fuyi could open the box and get the spirit stone inside within three days, she would rush over from the Flying Flower Sect¹² overnight and wash her feet for three months.

Ning Fuyi immediately became interested, quickly snatching one from the sect disciples. Unexpectedly, she became addicted to it and had already gone two days and one night without rest.

Chu Qingqiu's gaze became increasingly dissatisfied as she watched her. In the end, she lost all drowsiness, turned over barefoot to get off the bed. The outer half of the bed was perfectly flat and neat, clearly no one had slept there.

"Where are you going?" Ning Fuyi looked up with concern in her busy schedule, but only saw a corner of the other's clothing before hearing a bang - the door was slammed so hard that even the windows shook three times.

Ning Fuyi was startled by her, knowing the other was annoyed. She stared at the Three Sleepless Nights in her hands, which was only one mechanism away from being solved, but finally sighed and got up to chase after her.

Chu Qingqiu walked with a stern face through the front courtyard where autumn winds rustled, passing Ping'an¹³ and Bai Lin¹⁴ who were snuggling together in deep sleep. With a wave of her long sleeve, both beasts' mouths were immediately sealed, stopping their snoring while they opened their brass-bell-like eyes in unison.

"Noisy." Chu Qingqiu said a word, then stepped across the winding corridor bridge and entered the lakeside pavilion.

The pavilion had its supporting red pillars removed, its treasure-like canopy floating like green shade. Below it was placed a bamboo couch. Chu Qingqiu had been in a bad mood these past few days and had been cultivating here.

She leaned onto the couch, immortal energy circulating around her body. However, she didn't completely enter meditation, leaving her hearing consciousness outside to listen to the surrounding movements.

Soon someone rustled over and stopped in the pavilion.

"You can continue playing with your thing. Why follow this venerable one?" Chu Qingqiu said.

"I'm not playing anymore, it's not interesting." Ning Fuyi smiled sheepishly, sitting beside her and reaching out to massage her shoulders.

"Don't disturb my cultivation." Chu Qingqiu lightly shook her right shoulder, shaking off her hand.

"But you're not really cultivating." Ning Fuyi could see at a glance that her heart wasn't settled, so she muttered.

Chu Qingqiu's eyelashes trembled, and her immortal energy completely failed to maintain itself. After circulating once around her body, it hid back into her immortal meridians. Then she silently lowered her hands, and her flowing hair also returned to her shoulders.

"This venerable one wants to rest." Chu Qingqiu said again, turning her back to Ning Fuyi and half-reclining on the couch with her clothes on.

"You've already slept all night." Ning Fuyi continued muttering.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu could no longer bear it and finally turned around coldly. Just as she was about to lose her temper, Ning Fuyi quickly stepped forward, wrapping her arms tightly around her waist, placing her chin on her shoulder, and shamelessly nuzzling her cheek with her nose tip.

"I was wrong, terribly wrong. Divine Venerable is magnanimous, please don't be angry with me."

"You weren't wrong." Although Chu Qingqiu's words were blocked by her, her anger hadn't completely subsided, and she said coldly, "If the box is fun, go play with it. This venerable one won't disturb you."

"I'm not playing anymore. What's interesting about a broken box compared to accompanying you?" Ning Fuyi had recently practiced a glib tongue, smiling as she used the hair at her forehead to tickle Chu Qingqiu's neck.

Her obedient appearance nestled against the person's shoulder was exactly like a cat. Though her phoenix eyes were cunning, her appearance was beautiful. Back and forth, Chu Qingqiu's anger finally subsided somewhat.

Chu Qingqiu glanced at her from the corner of her eye and didn't chase her away anymore.

A few withered leaves rolled in from outside the palace walls, swirling in the wind for a while before falling onto the lake surface, creating ripples.

Seeing that she had smoothed down the thorns that had risen on the other person, Ning Fuyi then let her smile fade. Her eyes lingered between her brow bone and lip peak several times, then lightly supported herself on the bamboo couch and gave her a shallow kiss.

Seeing that Chu Qingqiu didn't refuse, the shallow kiss became a deep kiss. Her hand pressed toward her waist, and Chu Qingqiu's waist turned, facing her as she embraced her neck.

Heat rose in the autumn wind, lingering for a long time. The woman's breathless murmurs rose in fragments. No matter how many times one heard them, they always made one blush.

Ning Fuyi blushed as her hand moved downward. Chu Qingqiu sighed softly, half her body buried in her embrace, her hands clinging as if they had grown onto Ning Fuyi's body. Trembling as she cooperated with the other, her whole person was like the withered leaf that had just fallen into the water, spinning in the whirlpool.

The bamboo couch creaked and swayed. The slender legs trembled for a long time until finally, with a crack, it broke. Both their bodies rapidly descended then stopped, both freezing for a moment.

Ning Fuyi was the first to let out a low laugh. The heat from before immediately dissipated as she buried her face in Chu Qingqiu's neck, laughing uncontrollably. Chu Qingqiu turned completely red and pushed her face away with her hand.

"Who made this bamboo couch?" Chu Qingqiu complained while inconspicuously arranging her clothing, irritably smoothing out the wrinkles.

"I don't know. All the furnishings in this palace were arranged by the immortal attendants. They're all mortal objects. I'll talk to them about it." Ning Fuyi said, suppressing her laughter.

Chu Qingqiu looked up: "If you say even half a word about this matter, you can go back to the Demon Realm¹⁵ and never enter my Tranquil Mountain Palace again."

Ning Fuyi quickly raised both hands in surrender.

Chu Qingqiu lowered her eyes to arrange her clothing properly, then lazily lay in the autumn wind, extending her arms toward Ning Fuyi.

Seeing this, Ning Fuyi leaned down and slipped into her embrace, her hands encircling her back as she lifted the soft woman up. Her eyes were gentle as water as she kissed her nose tip, then said: "What's wrong?"

"The wind by the water is too strong, making me dizzy. Let's go back." Chu Qingqiu didn't move herself, only hanging her arms on Ning Fuyi's shoulders.

Ning Fuyi's smile couldn't fall from the corners of her mouth. Perhaps because they had been together for so long, recently Chu Qingqiu had also begun to unconsciously act willfully, having her do little things.

Of course, Chu Qingqiu would never admit this was acting spoiled, but in Ning Fuyi's eyes, every time she spoke with that tone, Ning Fuyi wanted nothing more than to flatten herself and give herself to her.

"Alright." Ning Fuyi said as she carried the person horizontally, not flying into the air but walking back through the autumn wind's rustling corridors, measuring the distance with her feet.

The autumn sky was vast and bright. Though the sunlight was bright, it was also cool. As Ning Fuyi carried the person past the drooping branches of the cotton rose tree¹⁶, Chu Qingqiu casually picked a milk-white flower and inserted it into Ning Fuyi's hair.

"In a few days there will be an initiation ceremony, and I'll have to make an appearance again." Chu Qingqiu sighed.

"Are you so unwilling to see people?" Ning Fuyi looked down. "No less than half the disciples in this realm came here admiring the name of you, Chu Ling Divine Venerable."

"You're now a living signboard for Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. I imagine Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate will soon rank among the top six sects." Ning Fuyi joked.

Unexpectedly, Chu Qingqiu wasn't modest: "It always has been."

Ning Fuyi was about to tease her when she suddenly sensed the barrier being touched. In the next instant, her arms were occupied by wind, and when she looked up again, the woman who had just been lying in her arms was now standing in the garden with her hands behind her back, displaying an air of noble dignity.

Ning Fuyi's hands froze in mid-air, then she crossed her arms and lowered her head, laughing so hard her shoulders shook.

The newcomer was Elder Pingyao¹⁷ with an anxious expression. She held something in her hand, so flustered that her usually neat collar was askew, and she stopped in front of Chu Qingqiu with a tense face.

"What does Elder Pingyao mean by this?" Chu Qingqiu also noticed her nervousness, extending her hand to steady her while asking in a deep voice.

Pingyao caught her breath a few times but didn't forget etiquette. She first bowed to Chu Qingqiu, then nodded to Ning Fuyi before speaking: "Does the Divine Venerable know about the recent instability in the celestial phenomena?"

Chu Qingqiu nodded in confusion: "Someone has already informed me of this matter, but from what I observed last night, though the celestial phenomena are unstable, they don't predict natural disasters."

"Is there some change now?" Chu Qingqiu frowned.

"There is indeed a change." Pingyao sighed deeply. "A few days ago it was merely unstable celestial phenomena, but just now Sect Leader Tang¹⁸ sent a letter saying that last night's star observation revealed the five planets have shifted, and Mars¹⁹ guards the heart - this is an extremely inauspicious omen."

"The study of constellations is unfathomably deep and has its own patterns. Though immortal sects often observe stars to predict fate, it's not always accurate. Elder, don't lose your composure." Ning Fuyi shook her head and interjected, walking to Chu Qingqiu's side.

"That's true, but I still had to urgently inform the Divine Venerable." Pingyao raised her sleeve to wipe the sweat from her forehead, but her expression didn't relax. "Moreover, there's another matter that's quite strange."

"What matter?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"Just now a masked woman at the foot of the mountain requested an audience." Elder Pingyao opened her mouth again, seeming to find it difficult to speak. Finally, she didn't explain further, only presenting the object she had been clutching in her hand to Chu Qingqiu, indicating for her to open it.

Chu Qingqiu and Ning Fuyi exchanged glances, then lifted the cloth wrapping the rod-shaped object. When the thing appeared before their eyes, both were shocked and pale.

Wrapped inside was a hairpin of superior quality jade, milk-white and lustrous in color, that both of them recognized very well - a white jade hairpin.

Footnotes:

1. **Eastern Desolation (东荒)**: A geographical region in the novel's world
2. **Dongyang City (东阳城)**: Literally "Eastern Sun City"
3. **Dianxing Town (点星镇)**: Literally "Star-Pointing Town"
4. **Cloud Ascension Mountain (云际山)**: The mountain where the sect is located
5. **Tranquil Mountain Palace (静山宫)**: Chu Qingqiu's residence
6. **Hanging Beam Garden (悬梁苑)**: A location within the sect for lessons
7. **Chu Ling Divine Venerable (褚凌神尊)**: Chu Qingqiu's title/name
8. **Qiu Wanwan (邱晚晚)**: A disciple's name, literally "Qiu Evening-Evening"
9. **Yiyi (衣衣)**: Ning Fuyi's nickname
10. **Three Sleepless Nights (三不寐)**: The name of the puzzle box
11. **Hua Feihua (花非花)**: A character whose name means "Flower Not-Flower"
12. **Flying Flower Sect (飞花教)**: The sect Hua Feihua belongs to
13. **Ping'an (平安)**: Name meaning "Peace/Safety" - one of the beast companions
14. **Bai Lin (白麟)**: Name meaning "White Qilin" - another beast companion
15. **Demon Realm (魔界)**: The realm where demons reside
16. **Cotton rose tree (木芙蓉树)**: A flowering tree, also known as Confederate rose
17. **Elder Pingyao (平遥长老)**: An elder of the sect
18. **Sect Leader Tang (唐掌门)**: Leader of another sect
19. **Mars (荧惑)**: In Chinese astronomy, Mars is called "Huòhuò" (荧惑), meaning "bewildering fire"